

DEBATE FACTIONS AND AFFIRMATIVE ACTIONS

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Dirt. Pleistocene fossil remains. Dallas Perkins. These are items on the increasingly short list of things older than I am. But with the costs of age come revenues, and one of those is that I have a somewhat longer view of debate history than the vast majority of us in the activity, who typically understand it only in four-year windows. Resisting the temptation to lecture about the smells of mimeograph fluid, how to use a microfilm machine, and the etymology of the word “card,” I will instead focus on three main points. First, I would like to review some of the historical fractionalizations our activity has survived. Second, I’d like to describe what I take to be our current splits, which I see as the result of class and not ideology. Third, I’d like to explore the implication of these splits, which I think is located in the ideas of Affirmative Action.

An Apocryphal History of Debate

Debate can trace its history through the Orient and the Occident several thousand years, but tournament-style competitive academic debate (or just “debate” from here on out) had its origins in the late nineteenth century, *Quarterly Journal of Speech* articles dating back to 1914 can still be found, and national championships emerged several decades later with the first NDT held in 1946. In 1947 the topic was “Resolved: That a federal world government should be established.” The actual defense of plans emerged in the middle to late 1960s, and prior to that time affirmatives defended what our current stable of debaters derisively refer to as “whole rez” – the defense of the entire resolution without a plan. Plans generated counter-plans, certainly practiced some time before Lichman and Rohrer’s seminal article made them a fixture of debate practice in 1974. (I refer the interested to Mr. Perkins for more precise carbon dating.) Early counterplan discussions were mostly about increasingly ridiculous standards of competition, but finally the community collectively

decided that mutual exclusivity and net benefits were pretty much the best measures of argument tension after all. Amidst the quibbling over theory arguments the meatball counterplan exploded, wearing a number of names that would bear striking resemblances to their antecedent critique arguments: World Government (harkening to 1947), socialism, anarchy, bioregions, and steady states. Paradigm debates flared up and burned out; “hypothesis testing,” “games theory,” “stock issues,” and other judging frames all collapsed when faced with the unassailably reasonable invincible “policy maker.”

Karla Leeper produced the grammatically horrific “permutation” (that word is correct, but its verb form is “permute” and not “permutate”) which contained a virus that contaminated the meatball, and by the early 1990s only a very small group of the very insistent relied on the big, generic counterplans as their A-game strategies. It is an interesting historical footnote that in 1985 Leeper reached the final round of the National Debate Tournament by defeating the Loyola (Los Angeles) team of Todd Gabler and John Doran, who had rolled into the semis of the NDT running a socialism counterplan as their only negative argument. As a measure of the size and resource status of the Loyola squad, Doran had by all accounts spent three months living out of his car by the time the semi-final debate happened. In the final round Leeper described herself as being from a “small school in Iowa” (she in fact attended the University of Iowa), but it was also the case that she was coached full-time by John Katsulas and Dale Herbeck, who collectively cut more cards (and actually taped them on four-by-six pieces of cardstock) than all the schools in California combined.

As the generic counterplan emerged from its cocoon in the form of a newer, more brightly colored species of “Plan Inclusive” negative argument, a significant rupture occurred in 1991. Coached by Bill Shanahan and Joel Rollins, Brian McBride issued the first ever “critique” while debating for Texas. Oh, sure, I had run the ground-breaking “deconstruction counterplan” in a few desperate situations as the low seed at large tournaments in early elims, but Brian was convincing when he said it. When I first heard it, I couldn’t figure out how a “critique” debate would be different from one of the old

“hypothesis testing” debates of the 1970s; at the Arizona Debate Institute in 1994 I boldly predicted the critique argument would die out in five years, just as the “hypo-testing” and socialism counterplans had completed their life cycles to extinction.

By 1997 I was coaching at Cal. State Fullerton and the only argument my team would run on either side of the topic was critical, and that more or less brings us up-to-date on my prognostication skills and the state of contemporary debate. Bill Shanahan ended up at Fort Hayes, and they ramped the weirdness up a notch. In 2001 West Georgia won an octo-final debate on the World Government counterplan (again, the entire topic in 1947), the morning after a near-miss on the first non-decision in the history of the NDT: Dartmouth and North Texas had found themselves in a spot where a discussion of debate, activism and critical theory broke out prior to the 2AR and lasted over an hour. A concession was offered and withdrawn, a subsequent flurry of discussion considered whether a 2AR was fair after the elapsed time, at least two judges left the room declaring they couldn’t decide the debate, and when the dust had settled and the tears were dried Dartmouth advanced. From what I can tell, in the year 2004 more than half of all debates involve some sort of critical argument, it is issued as often by the affirmative as the negative, and those who would resist constantly refer to a promised land of substantive debate that will get to the core of the real issues, but when taken up on the offer seem only able to present phantasmatic claims about political capital (“winners lose?”). Critical arguments have thoroughly saturated the debate world, as witnessed by the acumen demonstrated in those arguments by the old guard of our activity: Northwestern, Harvard, Dartmouth, Berkeley and Kansas (when they want to), and more.

I see pattern in all this. Since affirmatives have stopped defending the entire resolution, negatives have had a damnable time finding links. A Dartmouth team once literally ran a chicken dung case on the hazardous waste topic, Augustana granted one guy bar membership on the free speech topic (George Anastopolo) and got a first round, I myself advocated issuing Halley’s Comet pencils to Native Americans on the space exploration resolution. At first, negatives tried topicality, which worked as far as it went but the

collective judging pool seemed to have a distaste for it that was roughly akin to broccoli: You had to admit there was probably a place for it, but you didn't want it to dominate the menu. Then hypothesis testing tried to get the affirmative to defend against all possible better alternatives, which was at least one way for the negative to try to focus back to the resolution. When policy making killed that nonsense the meatball counterplan emerged, and if affirmatives wouldn't defend the core of the bloody topic negatives tried to make them defend all of capitalism or something equally unsavory. When permutations sent that strategy to the back burner the critique emerged, with negatives using their critiques to make affirmatives defend even broader things like Cartesianism or rationality or statism. The tool is different but the instinct is the same: Affirmatives don't have to defend the topic so they defend as little as possible, and negatives employ strategies to make them defend the broadest ground imaginable.

There is a second pattern. Debate arguments generally lag behind the academy by a decade or so. Marx and Marcuse were reverberating through universities in the 1960s and emerged as disads and counterplans in the 1970s. Foucault, Heidegger, and Derrida were the intellectual hotshots of the 1980s and 1990s and are now flowing out of the evidence tubs our students lug around. In this I find solace: Debate does and should reflect the divisions in the academy, and the academy is and should be in the business of pushing the intellectual envelope. Viewed this way, the factions in our debate universe are both necessary and productive. Necessary, because there's no reason to expect that if the policy wonks and critical philosophers can't get along in faculty meetings that their students will be any more cuddly at debate tournaments; productive, because our community of all others should recognize that the best way to ignite intellectual progress is to pit the best ideas of these camps against each before neutral audiences with skilled advocates. We can debate the format, what the core issues are, what counts as evidence, how that evidence should be presented, what the evidence proves, and even what our competitive academic debates are trying to accomplish, and the only thing we all have to agree on for this to happen is that we ought to debate.

The take-home point is this: The divisions and factions now lurking in our hallways and elim brackets are not new, nor even in my view as feisty as the divisions between the plan and the counterplan, the hypo-tester and the policy-maker, or the meatball and the permutation. They reflect real divisions in the intellectual traditions of our universities, and we would do well to welcome those points of contention into our activity. If all goes well, it might mean that through our debates our community can generate ideas that stimulate intellectual progress in those disputes, reconnecting us to the central mission of the university and making us seem less like a bizarre group of caffeine-sustained, poorly dressed frequent fliers who talk too fast and are otherwise irrelevant.

Class, not Ideology: The Curious Case of the Critique

If everyone – from Harvard to Cal. State Fullerton to Bakersfield Community College – now has a critique in their file box, and if I’m right about how completely critical debate has taken hold in contemporary academic debate, what’s left to fight about? What are these factions Al Louden is dedicating journal space to discuss? The relevant, emerging division is one that separates a group I will call the True Believers from one I will deem the Playas. The Playas generally like debate, get a kick out of competition, tend to think of it as a game or contest, and might or might not like philosophy but are generally willing to pursue any argument with strategic value that judges will probably vote for. Since it’s quite easy to win a link to a critique and they don’t generally bear the burden of uniqueness, there are decidedly some strategic advantages to the critique over the counterplan and disadvantage. The Playas tends to talk fast, and although they will debate out critiques, tend to take the attitude of Mike Horowitz, who once exclaimed to me after I’d voted for but generally mocked him: “I can debate the K like politics if I want to.” Fast, line-by-line oriented debate is fine with this group, be it Marcuse or Mead, and although some genuinely enjoy researching philosophers more than cutting snippets from the *Sacramento Bee* the style of debate is generally a settled issue for them.

The True Believers generally profess what is undoubtedly a genuine love for debate, do think competition is a good thing, and will freely admit that they enter the contest to try to win. They maintain, however, that the style of debate is not neutral and several features of the “game” as it is practiced privileges a certain sort of debater. Speaking really fast, using lots of evidence, and quoting often inaccessible policy experts or philosophers (reading Judith Butler is a quick and easy way to discover if you read at a 43rd grade level) privilege a certain type of debater. The same is true of debate theory jargon (try saying “Their K became a floating PIC which made our perm conditional, but since it was only a test of competition we severed and won the ground debate on aspec” at a cocktail party and see how many people want to talk to you). It’s easier to keep up on the research if you have access to a top-flight research library, can afford to pay for copying, own a wireless laptop, and are on a large squad with lots of people doing research. You can only understand the speed and the jargon if you spend a lot of time studying the minutia of debate and training your ear; this, in turn, is easier if you start in high school and go to one of the elite and expensive summer debate institutes. It’s easier to read Judith Butler, *International Affairs*, or the most recent article updating the science of the Greenhouse Effect in *Technology Review* if you start with a large vocabulary and an advanced reading level, which you are more likely to have if you attended a private high school than, say, one of the failing institutions that litter the landscape of the poorer parts of Los Angeles. For the True Believers, how the game is played is an important question, and many of the discursive practices that the Playas either enjoy or simply assume (reading cards, talking fast, taking flowsheets, answering arguments in a line-by-line fashion) they seek to call into question. And this is the question: Who do these practices privilege?

If you’re looking at the debate community and trying to find what factions or camps we’ve fallen into, categorizing debaters as critical and not-critical is yesterday’s category, as anachronistic as throwing Tom Jones, Donnie and Marie Osmond, the Beatles, and Snoop Doggy Dogg into a category called “Rock and Roll,” contrasting it with the swing music Glen Miller played, and lamenting that you can’t understand the words in the songs the kids

are listening to. The division of today is between those who are generally content with the contemporary style of debate and view critical argument as just another way to win, and those who really believe that how we debate must be changed to improve our participation levels and the educational value of what we do.

Well, what is the argument that started these shenanigans? If you were, perhaps to fight a bout of insomnia, to crack open an introductory rhetorical criticism text, you would no doubt discern that a central issue separating approaches would be the “ideological turn” – whether you should inquire about the political underpinnings and value orientations of an argument or text. This fundamental concept has brought into the academy and, about a decade later, into debate a host of ideas and claims that at first blush are ideological to the core and designed to expose, delegitimize, and perhaps even flatten hierarchies. If hierarchies end up being inevitable, this ideological focus might promise to at least counter some of the more obvious social injustices. Exposing the ideology of discourse has emancipatory potential, or so the critical theories promise (plus it lets you use big words nobody else understands).

I don’t know whether ideology is important or not, but I do know that the same eight to ten schools that were always winning the first rounds before the critique are roughly the same eight to ten schools that always get them after the critique. What seems much more important than the gap in ideology that separates a policy wonk like Jason Peterson from a critical fanatic like Bill Shanahan is the resource gap between the debate “haves” and the debate “have nots.” The haves enjoy a better travel schedule and hotel accommodations, benefit from access to better research facilities, copying, and computer technology, have larger squads that can produce more evidence, and get better coaching. They also typically are populated by students from good high school programs and thus have better debate-technique when they arrive: They can already spread, flow, and cut cards. *Given these advantages, the haves do better at tournaments regardless of the ideology of the arguments being presented.* Certainly, everyone who’s been around debate for any time period of four

years or longer will be able to name debaters who started without advantage that found success, but I believe these exceptions prove rather than deny the general rule.

Affirmative Action and Debate

These conclusions have led me to believe that the next major issue our activity will confront will be virtually identical to the affirmative action debate, and just as difficult for us to figure out. Is talking faster and more clearly, presenting more and better evidence, and making more wiley strategic choices an act of merit, or are these actions simply socially constructed and arbitrary; standards which benefit a certain class (the debate haves)? Can we pair students with vastly different backgrounds against one another and call it a fair contest? Imagine a debate where one side posts a student with four years of high school experience on a large college squad with 8 boxes of evidence, mostly backfiles and cards cut by others, who has finished a week giving nine rebuttal re-dos to a graduate student (I'm thinking somebody probably named "Garen" here). On the other side is an undergrad who debate at Los Angeles Jordan High School for a couple of years, went to a state school, has two boxes of Arizona Debate Institute evidence and has never had a coach hear a rebuttal. Is that a fair debate, even if judged neutrally? Much as the affirmative action literature has found that many seemingly color-blind or neutral standards – like quality of education, experience, and references – end up being racially coded, we in debate might find that our seemingly neutral standards of speech clarity and issue coverage, as well as quality of evidence and strategic choice, systematically favor the haves over the have-nots. If we decide that such a contest is not fair (come on, think it isn't), the choices are painful. Either we ask those with privilege to give it up, which will mean throwing out their file boxes, speaking slowly, and debating in a style where all their rebuttal re-dos don't matter at all, or we ask those without privilege to compete in unfair situations, that is, we will ask them to overcome far more to have the exact same levels of success as their more advantaged counterparts.

The more pleasant alternative is aggressive recruiting of minority participants. At present, this is work largely left to the Urban Debate Leagues (UDLs), a group of efforts in cities across America to generate competitive debating opportunities at poorer high schools. Whatever other benefits these leagues have offered their participants, they have not managed to change ethnic participation levels in college debate. It kills me to say that, since I'm one of the guys running one of those UDLs. But the national UDL Web site claims, and I believe them, that over 10,000 high school students have participated in the UDLs. If you check out the debateresults Web site (California State University, Fullerton, 2004), you'll find that no more than 1,400 undergraduates participate in competitive policy debate each year, and of those only 1,000 are truly active (a good yardstick for that measure is to consider that the average junior varsity basketball game in small towns in Indiana draws more people than participate in college debate each year). If even a very small percentage of those UDL students went on to college debate there should be an obvious and profound change in participation by ethnic group, and that has not happened. The best evidence we have on our demographics is a little dated (Skarb, 2003; Stepp & Gardner, 2001), but most of what you need to know is this: In any given round at one of our major tournaments, there are typically more African-American students debating for Louisville than from all other universities combined. The reasons the UDL has failed to fill the gap I've discussed elsewhere (Bruschke, 2003), but I do not think that by themselves the UDLs will eliminate the racial- and gender-coded participation gap in college debate.

There is one more limitation to the aggressive recruiting solution: Debate, in general, is ghettoized. Debate programs are not well funded and those that are typically get their support from alumni rather than general university coffers (making it all the more difficult for new programs to start and compete). Because time is so scarce and resources so few, there is very little in the way of time or scholarship money that anyone has to invest in aggressive minority recruitment. In simpler terms, it's just about the most that any of us can do to keep up with teaching, writing, coaching, and travel, and as a result recruiting generally takes a back burner for all directors, and any unified effort to change our activity

that adds to the recruiting burden is unlikely to go very far. This is not to say that recruiting shouldn't focus on minority students, but only that we will not change the face of our community by adding more requirements to the back-shelf tasks of our already overworked directors. We need changes that are more profound than that.

To summarize: We can decide our debates at present are fair, but they're not. We can point to those minorities who have overcome more than most and succeeded and insist other minorities do the same thing, although from what I can tell that's what we're doing now and it simply isn't working – the demographics of debate are *not* changing. Or we can call aggressive recruiting the solution, which I don't have much hope for given the reasons outlined above (the UDL failure and the general lack of director time and other resources), but most profoundly I think this solution evades the central question: If there's nothing about what we do that is race or gender coded, why is the university population 55% female but the debate population only 35%? Why is the university minority population 25% and the debate population only 15% (Stepp & Gardner, 2001)? Perhaps it is time to start talking and thinking about how the style of debate might influence participation levels. Perhaps, the best change is the one most easy for our community to adopt: Our debaters should start putting these questions of style on the table and debating them out.

I do not have the answers for our problems in these few pages, but I do think I have defined the issue: College debate stands at the precipice of a massive Affirmative Action debate, and our community would do well to investigate the issues that arise in those discussions and decide for ourselves what our best next step is. The broader Affirmative Action debate suggests the results will be messy and difficult to implement; asking those with privilege to renounce it is rarely an easy process. In many ways, the ghettoization of our activity has been our shield: Our programs are so small relative to the rest of the university that nobody really cares what we do, so nobody is going to fire up a lawsuit or do something else that would garner front-page attention for us, even negative attention. There is great possibility in this situation: we are, more or less, free to do what we want. Let's pick well, and move in the right direction because it's a choice we make and not because of

a policy edict from a Board of Regents. The best proof we'll ever have of the liberatory potential for competitive academic debate will be emancipating ourselves, and serving as a positive example of the diversity and respect that an open clash of ideas can create.

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